Mohini Pei

Character profiles

- **Mohini — The Protagonist**

Young adult · Tamil village · Player character

A thoughtful, affectionate young woman who dreams of choosing her own future. She is neither inherently rebellious nor submissive; she wants love, dignity and security without sacrificing her sense of self.

Visual identity: Ivory cotton saree, jasmine flowers, silver anklets, minimal jewellery. Her appearance gradually becomes more subdued as the story progresses.

Personality: Hopeful, observant, emotionally perceptive, increasingly determined.

- **The King — The Antagonist**

Adult · Royal household

A ruler whose affection for Mohini is inseparable from his social authority. He promises intimacy but avoids the public commitments that would challenge his position.

Visual identity: Dark maroon silk, gold ornaments, composed expression.

Personality: Charming, calculating, concerned with preserving his status.

- **Mohini's Mother — The Conflicted Protector**

Middle-aged · Family household · Supporting character

She loves Mohini but fears the consequences of opposing powerful people. She represents how individuals may reproduce social expectations even when they recognise their injustice.

Visual identity: Muted earth-toned saree, tied-back hair, tired expression.

Personality: Protective, anxious, restrained.

- **Meena — The Friend**

Young adult · Village resident · Supporting character

Mohini's childhood friend. She is willing to help but has limited resources and must negotiate pressures from her own household.

Visual identity: Faded green saree, simple bangles, practical clothing.

Personality: Loyal, resourceful, cautious.

- **The Village — The Collective Voice**

Neighbours, elders, palace officials · Collective supporting characters

Not a single villain, but a network of people whose gossip, silence, decisions and institutional authority shape Mohini's social standing.

Visual identity: Faces partly obscured, figures gathered in doorways, overlapping voices.

Narrative role: Demonstrates how reputations are produced collectively.

Detailed scene-by-scene storyboard

Scene 01 — The King's Attention

Setting: A village festival, late afternoon. Mohini is with her friend. The sound of her anklets mingles with festival music.

On-screen narration:

> Jasmine is threaded into your hair. Your friend laughs as your silver anklets ring against the stone.
>
> Your family works on land controlled by the royal estate; your caste-marginalised community sustains the village but has little voice in its decisions.
>
> For a moment you are simply Mohini, with a future large enough to imagine.
>
> Then the king's attendant approaches. The ruler wishes to speak with you.
>
> Your mother sees a rare opportunity for a family with few resources; your friend sees the guards behind him.

Dialogue:

Mohini: "Why would he notice someone from our community?"

Attendant: "You should be honoured."

His voice leaves little room for refusal.

On-screen question: What will you do?

Choice button	Consequence shown after selection
A. Accept the invitation	You enter the palace garden. He speaks gently, but the attendant notes your name and home. An invitation has quietly become an expectation.
B. Decline politely	The attendant's smile vanishes. By evening, your mother has heard that you insulted the palace.
C. Ask your family first	Your mother squeezes your hand. "A king does not ask twice." Her concern is real; so is her fear.

Transition: The palace becomes a recurring presence in Mohini's life. The next scene moves to her developing relationship with the king.

Visual and audio cues: Warm lighting, jasmine petals and festival music. When the attendant arrives, the music becomes quieter and the palace guards appear in the background.

Intersectional significance: Gender, caste and economic dependence shape the consequences of what initially appears to be a personal invitation.

Scene 02 — The Promise

Setting: A secluded palace garden, evening. Mohini and the king are alone.

On-screen narration:

> He remembers the flowers you wear. He asks what kind of life you dream of.
>
> You speak of learning, travelling, and choosing your own future.
>
> "I will marry you," he says. "But not yet. The court must not know."

Dialogue:

Mohini: "Is it my caste that troubles them, or the thought of someone like me standing beside you?"

The king looks away.

King: "What we have does not need their approval."

Mohini: "It is easy to say that, when their disapproval will never cost you your home."

On-screen narration continues:

> For a moment you want to believe him. Then you realise that only one of you can afford for this promise to remain a secret.

On-screen question: How do you answer?

Choice button	**Consequence shown after selection**
A. Believe him and wait	You fold his letter beneath your pillow. Weeks pass. His messenger arrives less often. Your hope becomes something you must hide.
B. Ask him to acknowledge you publicly	He grows cold. "Do you doubt my word?" The court begins describing you as demanding.
C. End the relationship	He does not stop you. But the village already knows you entered the palace, and it invents a story for your silence.

Transition: The king's letters become less frequent. The village begins constructing its own account of their relationship.

Visual and audio cues: Begin with golden candlelight, then transition to cooler shadows. Show a folded letter and jasmine flowers. The background music gradually fades.

Intersectional significance: The king's private affection does not eliminate the unequal power created by caste and royal authority. Mohini cannot secure public recognition on the same terms as him.

Scene 03 — The Village Whispers

Setting: Village market, midday. Conversations stop as Mohini approaches.

On-screen narration:

> At the market, conversations stop when you approach.
>
> A woman who once bought jasmine from you now looks away.
>
> Someone says you pursued the king. Someone else says a woman of your caste should have known her place.
>
> A neighbour mutters that the ruler was generous even to notice you.
>
> You look across the square and see his banners carried past, immaculate.
>
> Your name and caste are being discussed. His is being celebrated.

Suggested on-screen whisper overlays:

> "She should have known her place."
>
> "Did she really think he would marry her?"
>
> "The king was generous even to notice her."

On-screen question: How will you respond?

Choice button	Consequence shown after selection
A. Tell everyone what he promised	You speak clearly. The crowd asks why you were alone with him in the first place. Your truth is made into another accusation.
B. Stay silent to protect your family	Your father thanks you for not causing trouble. Later you hear a neighbour call your silence a confession.

C. Seek an elder's intervention	The elder says a dispute with the palace would shame the village. He advises you to forget the matter.

Transition: Mohini returns home as the rumours intensify. The king's withdrawal becomes explicit in the next scene.

Visual and audio cues: Use overlapping whispers, partially obscured faces and tighter framing. The king's banners remain visible to contrast his public standing with Mohini's deteriorating reputation.

Intersectional significance: Mohini's credibility is shaped not simply by her gender but also by her caste position and the authority of the man she is challenging.

Scene 04 — The Closed Doors

Setting: Mohini's family home, night. A final letter from the palace has arrived.

On-screen narration:

> The king's final letter arrives without a signature: there will be no marriage.
>
> Your family fears losing work on the royal estate if you challenge him.
>
> Your mother sits beside you but cannot meet your eyes.

Dialogue:

Mother: "I believe you. But what can we do? If the estate turns us away, where will we go?"

Mohini: "I'm not asking you to fight a king. I'm asking you to stand beside me."

On-screen narration continues:

> Your father has barred the gate, hoping the gossip will pass.
>
> The room is full of people who love you.
>
> It has never felt so lonely.

On-screen question: Who will you turn to?

Choice button	Consequence shown after selection
A. Ask your family to stand beside you	Your mother holds your hand. Your father fears the palace. They argue while you wait for a decision about your own life.
B. Petition the royal court	A clerk refuses to register your complaint. He dismisses a woman from your community before hearing her evidence. The king's word, he says, is not for you to question.
C. Confide in your closest friend	Your friend offers a place to sleep and the money she has saved. It is not enough to undo the harm, but you are no longer alone.

Transition: Mohini leaves the house before dawn, uncertain whether she can remain in the village.

Visual and audio cues: Rain against the roof, a dim oil lamp and a closed door. The music stops during her conversation with her mother.

Intersectional significance: The scene demonstrates the distinction between emotional support and material power. Mohini's family may believe her, but its dependence on the estate limits its ability to intervene. Her friend, meanwhile, demonstrates that agency can be supported through everyday relationships.

This is one of the most important scenes for Phoenix's discussion of structure and agency.

Scene 05 — The Last Jasmine

Setting: A road beyond the village, before dawn.

On-screen narration:

> You walk beneath trees that once sheltered your laughter.
>
> The jasmine in your hair has dried.
>
> In the distance, the palace lamps still burn.

You could go back and ask for mercy. You could leave without money, connections or a place to stay. You could ask the village to hear you one final time.

You are tired of begging to be believed.

But you are not tired of wanting to live.

On-screen question: What do you choose?

Choice button	Consequence shown after selection
A. Go to the palace one final time	The gates do not open. You wait until morning, holding a promise that the palace has already forgotten.
B. Leave the village	You take the road into darkness. No one knows where you went. Rumour fills the silence long before anyone tries to find you.
C. Ask the village to hear your account	A few neighbours listen. Others turn away. Your friend remembers every word, even when the public story changes.

Transition: The screen gradually fades to black. The ending begins after a short pause.

Visual and audio cues: Dried jasmine petals, a distant palace and an empty road. The sound of anklets fades. Avoid a graphic death scene or an explicit depiction of suicide.

Intersectional significance: Mohini continues to exercise agency, but the consequences of her decisions remain shaped by economic resources, caste hierarchy, relationships and institutional authority.

Final Scene — The Woman Becomes the Ghost

On-screen narration:

Days later, Mohini is missing.

Some say she died beyond the village. Others say she wandered away and never returned.

The story never tells us which account is true.

Years pass.

People speak of a beautiful spirit in jasmine and anklets who waits for men after sunset.

They call her dangerous.

They do not speak of the king's promise, the closed gates, or the friend who searched for her.

You played a life with desires and relationships.

The village remembers only a warning, not the caste hierarchy, dependence on estate work, or unequal power that shaped her choices.

ENDING UNLOCKED: The Woman the Village Forgot

"He returned to his palace. I became a story told to frighten strangers."

Required on-screen note:

Mohini's disappearance and presumed death are fictional. Her caste-marginalised background, the royal estate and her relationship with the king are creative devices for exploring intersectionality, not verified facts about Mohini Pei's folkloric origin.

Next button: What if her circumstances had been different?

Post-game: The "What If?" experience

The reflection should appear after the ending, without requiring the player to restart the game.

Debate 1 — Structure and Agency

On-screen question: What if Mohini had different forms of support?

Few allies or resources

Without reliable support or independent resources, Mohini's options for confronting the palace or leaving the village remain limited.

Phoenix's connection: Individual agency and structural power must be examined together.

Debate 2 — Which Intersections Matter?

On-screen question: What if one aspect of Mohini's social position changed?

Caste positioning

A different caste position might change Mohini's access to influential allies, the credibility assigned to her testimony and expectations surrounding marriage. Wealth alone would not necessarily erase caste boundaries.

Phoenix's connection: Relevant intersections must be understood in their particular cultural and historical contexts.

Debate 3 — How Do We Understand Identity?

On-screen question: What changes when we examine Mohini's life through a different lens?

Intra-categorical — Examine her individual life

Mohini is not representative of every Tamil woman or every person from a caste-marginalised community. Her aspirations, relationships and decisions make her experience particular.

Phoenix's connection: Different approaches to intersectionality reveal different dimensions of identity, inequality and lived experience.

These three sections are creative applications of the debates Phoenix discusses, not empirical findings about historical Tamil society.

Phoenix_interrogating intersectionality.pdf

Final reflection screen

MONST(H)ER · INTERSECTING LIVES

"Her identity did not determine her fate. But it shaped the possibilities she was given."

A single legend can never hold every version of a life.

More stories. More lives. More intersections.

Final navigation: Explore the Red Bride and Return Home.